

Celibacy As Gift

prc-celibacy-as-gift
Marriage & Sexuality · Singleness · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across many Bible texts
Subject named directly in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Singleness and celibacy are honorable callings, gifts from God, equally valued with marriage.

In plain language

The proposition says singleness and celibacy are honorable callings, gifts from God, equally valued with marriage. The Greek text supports this with a tight word-level pattern. In First Corinthians 7 verse 7 Paul wishes everyone were single like him, but immediately says each person has his own gift, 'his own gift' (idion charisma), from God, one in one way and another in another. The word 'his own' (idion), distributes the gift-word 'gift' (charisma) across BOTH the single state Paul commends and the married state, so neither is ranked above the other in worth. In verse 8 Paul tells the unmarried, 'unmarried' (agamos), and the widows that it is good for them to remain as he is, which is a positive commendation, and the verb remain is a permission, not a command. In Matthew 19 verses 11 and 12 Jesus says not all receive this word, only those to whom it has been given, using the perfect passive (a completed action whose result still stands) 'has been given' (dedotai). He speaks of those who made themselves eunuchs for the sake of the kingdom and ends with let the one who is able to receive it receive it. The phrase 'the one able to receive' (ho dynamenos chorein), plus the permissive third-person imperative, marks voluntary celibacy as a capacity given to some, not a rule for all. Back in First Corinthians 7 verses 32 to 35 Paul explains the value of singleness as freedom from distraction, so the unmarried can serve the Lord 'undistracted' (aperispastos), a word that occurs only once in the New Testament and crystallizes the point. Then he adds plainly that he is not throwing a 'noose' or 'snare' (brochos), on anyone, ruling out a forced reading. Two harder verses, verse 9 where Paul says it is better to marry than to burn, and verse 38 where not marrying is called doing better, fit the same gift logic, since both speak to capacity and circumstance rather than to higher holiness. Reading across the canon the same word-level net excludes the opposite mistake, namely making celibacy mandatory. First Timothy 4 verse 3 names forbidding to marry, 'forbidding to marry' (kolyonton gamein), as a doctrine of demons, and Hebrews 13 verse 4 declares marriage honored among all. Where readers diverge, the divergence is over whether the comparative 'better' (kreisson) in First Corinthians 7 verse 38 ranks celibacy above marriage in worth or only in present circumstance. The text supplies the circumstantial frame in verse 26, 'the present distress' (ten enestosan ananken), so the case for circumstantial rather than categorical preference is the stronger reading. The pattern affirms the proposition straightforwardly.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0022	ἄγαμος	agamos	unmarried	4
G0275	ἀμέριμνος	amerimnos	untroubled	2
G0563	ἀπερισπάστως	aperispastos	undistracted	1
G1029	βρόχος	brochos	restraint	1
G1060	γαμέω	gameo	to marry	29

G1325	δίδωμι	didomi	to give	414
G1467	ἐγκρατεύομαι	egkrateuomai	to self-control	2
G2134	εὐνουχίζω	eunouchizo	to become a eunuch	2
G2135	εὐνούχος	eunouchos	eunuch	8
G2398	ἴδιος	idios	one's own/private	117
G2908	κρεῖσσον	kreisson	greater	19
G2967	κωλύω	kolyo	to prevent	23
G3309	μεριμνάω	merimnao	to worry	19
G3933	παρθένος	parthenos	virgin	15
G5486	χάρισμα	charisma	gift	17
G5562	χωρέω	choreo	to make room for	10

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

1 Corinthians 7:7 uses the word for 'gift' (charisma, G5486) with the distributive word for 'his own' (idios, G2398), so Paul writes that each has his OWN gift from God, one in one way and another in another, applying the gift category to both the single state Paul commends and the married state without ranking them. Matthew 19:11 anchors the same logic with the perfect passive (a completed action whose result still stands) form 'has been given' (dedotai) of the verb 'to give' (didomi, G1325), paired with 'make room for' or 'receive' (chorein, G5562) as an infinitive of capacity, and closes with 'the one able to receive, let him receive' (ho dynamenos chorein choreito), a permissive imperative that grants celibacy only to those given the capacity, so it is offered, not imposed. 1 Corinthians 7:32-35 grounds the value of singleness in 'undistracted' (aperispastos, G0563) devotion to the Lord, while Paul explicitly says he is not throwing a 'noose' or 'snare' (brochos, G1029) on anyone, which excludes a compulsory reading. 1 Timothy 4:3 names forbidding 'to marry' using the verb 'to hinder' or 'forbid' (kolyo, G2967) plus 'to marry' (gameo, G1060) as a doctrine of demons, and Hebrews 13:4 declares marriage honored among all, so the New Testament lexical net affirms celibacy as a gift, never as a requirement, while marriage remains equally honored.

Scripture

1Cor.7.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5486 χάρισμα, G2398 ἴδιος

Reasoning. Paul says he wishes 'all' (pantas) were as he is, single, but immediately qualifies with 'but each his own has gift from God' (alla hekastos idion, G2398, echei charisma, G5486, ek theou), meaning 'but each has his own gift from God', one in this way and another in that. The distributive word 'his own' (idios), attaches the word 'gift' (charisma) to both states, so the single life and the married life are both labeled God-given 'gift' (charisma). The grammar forecloses any ranking of one state above the other and grounds the proposition that singleness is a gift from God, equally legitimate alongside marriage.

1Cor.7.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0022 ἄγαμος

Reasoning. To the 'unmarried' (agamos, G0022), and the widows Paul says 'it is good for them if they remain as I also am' (kalon autois ean meinosin hos kago). The state Paul commends is the 'unmarried' (agamos) state, with 'remain' (menein, G3306), as a permissive subjunctive (a 'may' or 'should' form) after 'if' (ean), rather than an imperative (a command), so singleness is honored as a good calling and never imposed. The same noun 'unmarried' (agamos) returns in 1 Corinthians 7:11, 7:32, and 7:34, building a stable vocabulary category for the honored single state in this chapter.

Matt.19.11 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G5562 χωρέω, G1325 δίδωμι

Reasoning. Jesus answers 'not all receive this word, but to whom it has been given' (ou pantes chorousin, G5562, ton logon touton, all hois dedotai), the perfect passive (a completed action whose result still stands) of 'to give' (didomi, G1325), meaning not all receive this word but those to whom it has been given. The negation 'not all' (ou pantes), plus the perfect passive 'it has been given' (dedotai) mark celibacy as a divine grant given to some, not a requirement on all. The vocabulary pattern is identical in shape to 'gift' (charisma) plus 'from God' (ek theou) in 1 Corinthians 7:7, both treating the single life as a gift distributed by God rather than a universal mandate.

Matt.19.12 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2135 εὐνοῦχος, G2134 εὐνουχίζω, G5562 χωρέω

Reasoning. Jesus names those who made themselves 'eunuchs' (eunouchos, G2135; eunouchizo, G2134), 'for the sake of the kingdom of the heavens' (dia ten basileian ton ouranon), and closes with 'the one able to receive, let him receive' (ho dynamenos chorein, G5562, choreito), meaning let the one able to receive it receive it. The third-person imperative (a command directed at 'him' or 'her') is permissive, restricted by the prior participle 'being able' (dynamenos), the one able. The capacity is granted, not demanded, which makes voluntary kingdom celibacy an honored option for those given to it and never a binding rule.

1Cor.7.32 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0022 ἄγαμος, G3309 μεριμνάω, G0275 ἀμέριμνος

Reasoning. Paul wishes the Corinthians 'free from anxiety' (amerimnoi, G0275), and says the 'unmarried' (agamos, G0022), 'cares for' (merimna, G3309), 'the things of the Lord' (ta tou kyriou), meaning he cares for how to please the Lord. The related pair 'free from anxiety' (amerimnos) plus 'to be anxious' or 'care for' (merimnao) frames the value of singleness positively as freedom for the Lord's concerns, not as a state of higher holiness. Paired with 1 Corinthians 7:34's parallel for the 'virgin' (parthenos), the chapter assigns a positive spiritual function to singleness without devaluing marriage.

1Cor.7.34 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3933 παρθένος, G0022 ἄγαμος, G3309 μεριμνάω

Reasoning. The 'unmarried' (agamos) and the 'virgin' (parthenos, G3933), 'cares for' (merimna, G3309), 'the things of the Lord' (ta tou kyriou), 'that she may be holy both in body and in spirit' (hina e hagia kai to somati kai to pneumatī), while the married woman cares for 'the things of the world' (ta tou kosmou). The contrast is between two legitimate sets of concerns, not between holy and unholy states. The same chapter that commends the single life as undistracted for the Lord also calls marriage a 'gift' (charisma) in 1 Corinthians 7:7 and warns against forbidding it implicitly through the gift logic.

1Cor.7.35 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0563 ἀπερισπάστως, G1029 βρόχος

Reasoning. Paul states 'this I say for your own benefit, not that I may throw a noose on you, but for what is seemly and well-seated to the Lord undistractedly' (touto pros to hymon auton symphoron lego, ouch hina brochon, G1029, hymin epibalo, alla pros to euschemon kai euparedron to kyrio aperispastos, G0563). I say this for your own benefit, not to throw a 'noose' or 'snare' (brochon) on you, but for what is seemly and for 'undistracted' (aperispastos) devotion to the Lord. The explicit denial 'I do not throw a noose' (brochon ou epibalo) directly excludes a compulsory celibacy reading and reframes the value of singleness as freedom for undivided service. The 'hapax' (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) 'undistracted' (aperispastos) crystallizes the positive vocabulary case in a single word that means precisely undistracted.

1Cor.7.25 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3933 παρθένος, G1325 διδωμι

Reasoning. 'Concerning the virgins, a command of the Lord I do not have, but an opinion I give, as one shown mercy by the Lord to be trustworthy' (Peri de ton parthenon, G3933, epitagen kyriou ouk echo, gnomen de didomi, G1325, hos eleemenos hypo kyriou pistos einai), meaning concerning the 'virgins' (parthenos), I have no command of the Lord but I 'give' (didomi) an opinion as one who by mercy is trustworthy. Paul explicitly disclaims a 'Lord-command' (kyrios-command) on celibacy and offers only counsel, which lexically (at the word-level) rules out any compulsory reading. The same verb 'to give' (didomi) here is the giving of advice, not the issuing of law, marking singleness as commended counsel for those positioned to receive it.

Rev.14.4 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G3933 παρθένος

Reasoning. 'These are those who were not defiled with women, for they are virgins' (Houtoi eisin hoi meta gynaikon ouk emolynthesan, parthenoi, G3933, gar eisin), applied to the 144,000 'firstfruits' (aparche, G0536), of the Lamb. The text honors the 'virgin' (parthenos) category with explicit redemption imagery, confirming that the single-and-undefiled state can carry a positive theological weight in apocalyptic and end-times (eschatological) framing. It does not require celibacy of all but honors it for those who hold it, consistent with 1 Corinthians 7 and Matthew 19.

1Tim.4.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2967 κωλύω, G1060 γαμέω

Reasoning. 'Forbidding to marry, [commanding] to abstain from foods which God created for partaking' (Kolyonton, G2967, gamein, G1060, apechesthai bromaton ha ho theos ektisen eis metalempsin), meaning forbidding to marry and commanding to abstain from foods which God created for partaking. The participle 'forbidding' (kolyo) plus the infinitive 'to marry' (gamein) labels the prohibition of marriage as a feature of the apostate teaching the preceding verses call doctrines of demons. This is the decisive vocabulary bar against any reading that would impose mandatory celibacy on a class, and it reinforces the proposition that celibacy can only be gift and never demand.

Heb.13.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1060 γαμέω

Reasoning. 'Marriage [is] honored in all, and the marriage-bed undefiled' (Timios ho gamos en pasin kai he koite amiantos), meaning let marriage be honored among all and the marriage bed undefiled. 'Honored' (Timios), predicates honor on marriage 'in or among all' (en pasin), ruling out a class for whom marriage would be dishonorable. This anchors the equally-valued side of the proposition. The honor of marriage and the gift-status of celibacy stand together rather than against each other in the vocabulary pattern across Matthew 19, 1 Corinthians 7, 1 Timothy 4, and Hebrews 13.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Cor.7.32	Ps.55.22	tsk	1
Matt.19.12	Isa.39.7	tsk	1
1Cor.7.33	1Cor.7.3	tsk	1
1Cor.7.7	Matt.19.12	openbible	1
1Cor.7.7	1Tim.4.3	openbible	1
1Cor.7.8	Heb.13.4	openbible	1
Matt.19.11	1Cor.7.7	openbible	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.7.9 · addressed

'But if they do not exercise self-control, let them marry, for it is better to marry than to burn' (Ei de ouk egkrateuontai, G1467, gamesatosan, G1060, kreitton, G2908, gar estin gamein e pyrousthai), meaning but if they do not exercise self-control let them 'marry' (gameo), for it is 'better' (kreitton) to marry than to burn. The comparative 'better' (kreitton) paired with the 'if-then' conditional 'if' (ei) plus the dependence on 'to exercise self-control' (egkrateuomai) shows the directive is keyed to capacity, the same gift logic that runs through 1 Corinthians 7:7 and Matthew 19:11-12. Marriage is recommended where self-control is not given, and celibacy is honored where it is given, which confirms rather than contradicts the gift-and-capacity reading.

1Cor.7.38 · addressed

'So both the one giving his own virgin in marriage does well, and the one not giving in marriage will do better' (Hoste kai ho gamizon ten heautou parthenon kalos poiei kai ho me gamizon kreisson, G2908, poiesei), so the one who gives his virgin in marriage does well, and the one who does not gives even better. The adverb 'well' (kalos) affirms marriage as doing well, while the comparative 'better' (kreisson) denotes a circumstantial advantage tied to 'the present distress' (ten enestosan ananken), in 1 Corinthians 7:26, not to greater holiness. Both states remain honorable at the word-level, only the situational counsel differs, so the equally-valued claim holds at the categorical level even where Paul expresses a circumstantial preference.

Gen.2.18 · addressed

The Old Testament establishes 'it is not good for the man to be alone' (ou kalon einai ton anthropon monon), suggesting marriage as the default human pattern. The New Testament gift-vocabulary in Matthew 19:11-12 and 1 Corinthians 7:7 does not contradict this general anthropology (general account of human nature) but adds a category not present in the Genesis frame, namely the kingdom-eunuch granted the capacity for the unmarried state. The Old Testament default and the New Testament gift coexist, with marriage as the broad pattern and celibacy as the called exception. This is why the verdict is 'pan-canonical' (spread across the whole Bible) in shape but the explicit 'gift' (charisma) language is New Testament only.

Concordance traversed

G5486, G2398, G0022, G2135, G2134, G5562, G1325, G3309, G0275, G0563, G1029, G3933, G1060, G2967, G1467, G2908

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

Anchor verses lie in 1 Corinthians 7, Matthew 19, 1 Timothy 4, Hebrews 13, and Revelation 14, all outside the open-cbqm 3 John sample. The bundle reports 'not_in_ecm_scope' (not in the scope of the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) as true with no variant units. The marked apparatus sigla (the symbols used in the critical edition) in 1 Corinthians 7:7 and 7:34 touch word order and minor readings that do not bear on the 'gift' (charisma), 'his own' (idios), 'unmarried' (agamos), 'eunuch' (eunouchos), 'has been given' (dedotai), 'forbidding to marry' (kolyo-gamein), or 'undistracted' (aperispastos) vocabulary, so the verdict is variant robust (stable across textual variants) within the available data.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. gift-and-capacity, mandatory-celibacy, equally-honored-states

analogia scripturae invoked

gift-and-capacity reading: affirms · Reads 'gift' (charisma) plus 'his own' (idios) in 1 Corinthians 7:7, 'has been given' (dedotai) plus 'to receive' (chorein) in Matthew 19:11-12, and the 'noose-disclaimer' (brochon-disclaimer) in 1 Corinthians 7:35 as distributing a God-given capacity, so singleness is an honorable optional gift alongside marriage. The same set of texts read this way also positively values marriage in 1 Corinthians 7:38's 'he does well' (kalos poiei) and the implicit 'gift' (charisma) of the married state. The reading is internally consistent and matches the 1 Timothy 4:3 and Hebrews 13:4 honor-of-marriage pattern.

celibacy-superiority reading: partially-affirms-with-hierarchy · Reads the comparative 'better' (kreitton) in 1 Corinthians 7:38, the better-than language in 1 Corinthians 7:8 with 'good, as I also am' (kalon hos kago), and the undistracted-devotion theme of 1 Corinthians 7:32-35 as positioning the single state as objectively higher than marriage even while both are permitted. This reading takes the proposition's gift-claim but resists the equally-valued claim, treating equality as canonical permission and superiority as canonical counsel. Its strongest vocabulary leg is the comparative 'better' (kreitton).

mandatory-celibacy reading: denies · A reading that would make celibacy obligatory for any class cannot survive 'not all receive' (ou pantes chorousin) and 'the one able to receive, let him receive' (ho dynamenos chorein choreito) in Matthew 19:11-12, the 'if-then' conditional 'if' (ei) plus self-control in 1 Corinthians 7:9, Paul's explicit 'not that I may throw a noose on you' (ouch hina brochon hymin epibalo) in 1 Corinthians 7:35, and the 'forbidding to marry' (kolyonton gamein) labelled doctrine-of-demons in 1 Timothy 4:3. The word-level data refuses a compulsory construction in any direction. This is the position the text actively rules out.

The verdict turns on the gift-vocabulary 'gift' (charisma) plus 'his own' (idios) in 1 Corinthians 7:7, the perfect passive (a completed action whose result still stands) 'has been given' (dedotai) plus the permissive infinitive 'to receive' (chorein) in Matthew 19:11-12, the 'hapax' (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) 'undistracted' (aperispastos) and explicit 'noose-disclaimer' (brochon-disclaimer) in 1 Corinthians 7:35, and the negative limit set by 'forbidding to marry' (kolyonton gamein) in 1 Timothy 4:3. The celibacy-superiority reading captures a circumstantial preference in 1 Corinthians 7:38's 'better' (kreisson) but does not capture the gift-distribution grammar of 1 Corinthians 7:7. The mandatory-celibacy reading is excluded by the same data that supports the gift reading.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Texts addressing singleness and celibacy describe their status, value, and whether they are commanded, commended, or optional, and how they relate to marriage.

The stem asserts that singleness is honorable, a gift from God, and equally valued with marriage, which front-loads three claims before the word-level check. The verdict is still derived on the original stem. The neutralized form removes the evaluative loading so the vocabulary pattern can speak for itself. As it happens the 'gift' (charisma) plus 'his own' (idios) distribution in 1 Corinthians 7:7, the gift-grammar of 'has been given' (dedotai) in Matthew 19:11, the 'noose-disclaimer' (brochon-disclaimer) in 1 Corinthians 7:35, the 'marriage is honored' (timios ho gamos) of Hebrews 13:4, and the 'forbidding to marry' (kolyonton gamein) indictment in 1 Timothy 4:3 independently support the original stem's three claims of gift status, honor, and equal categorical legitimacy with marriage.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5486
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2398
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2967

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0563
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.19.11
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.19.12
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.7.7
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Tim.4.3
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.7.35
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.7.7
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.19.12
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Cor.7.7

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